

Handoffs a cloud session can actually read

A cloud Claude Code session **clones this repository**. It cannot see anything Git ignores — which includes all of `design-docs/`.

So a handoff written for a cloud session lives **here**, tracked, or it is not reachable at all. Handing a session a `design-docs/handoffs/...` path gives it a path to a file that does not exist in its world.

That mistake has now been made twice: the untracked `CLOUD-1..6` batch on 2026-08-23 and the `CLOUD-7..10` batch on 2026-08-25. Both times all the sessions asked the same question at once, which is the tell.

The rule

- A handoff for a cloud session goes in `docs/handoffs/`, is committed, and is pushed before the session is told about it.
- A handoff for a local session may stay in `design-docs/handoffs/` — a session on this box reads the disk directly, so the gitignore is irrelevant there.
- Give the session the **in-repo path**, and the one command that reaches it even before the branch is merged:

```
git fetch origin && git show origin/main:docs/handoffs/<file>.md
```

Why these are tracked rather than pasted

Pasting a 300-line prompt into four sessions is slow, error-prone, and painful on a tablet. It also leaves no record of what each session was actually told — and the record is the point: these documents state the acceptance criteria a PR is judged against, and a later reader deserves to see the instructions beside the result.

Historical note, kept deliberately: each of these carries corrections to the plan that produced it, found by checking the repository rather than trusting the issue. Two of the four say the job is not what its issue claims. That is worth reading before writing the next batch.

The 25 August batch — CLOUD-1 ... CLOUD-6

Numbered by MERGE ORDER, not by when they were written. "Run 1 first" and "merge 1 first" are deliberately the same number, so a session's name is also its place in the queue.

#	Handoff	Issue(s)	ADR	Merge order
1	CLOUD-1-issue-495-stash-dtos.md	#495	0079	FIRST of all six — rewrites stash field names everywhere; everything else would pay for its rebase
2	CLOUD-2-issues-493-494-stash-executor.md	#493 + #494	0078	after #1
3	CLOUD-3-issue-485-journal-quadratic.md	#485	0080	before #6 — shares <code>activity.rs</code> and <code>planner/fetch.rs</code> with it
4	CLOUD-4-issue-438-parallel-test-race.md	#438	0083	independent
5	CLOUD-5-issues-496-365-fixtures-finished.md	#496 + #365	0082	independent
6	CLOUD-6-issue-486-tips-unknown-fold.md	#486	0081	after #3 — same two files, and the collision is textual

Only two of the six are truly independent (#4 and #5). The batch's own truth-check found that #3 and #6 both edit `crates/git-vista-core/src/activity.rs` and `crates/git-vista-server/src/planner/fetch.rs` — and not incidentally: they edit the same doc-comment block, `activity.rs` ~601-624, which lists two known defects, one each. Each fix deletes its own numbered item and whichever lands second must reword the block header. Both handoffs originally claimed to be independent. Both were wrong.

ADR numbers are assigned here, up front, on purpose. When four sessions run at once and each picks "the next free number", they all pick the same one and the index conflicts. That happened on 25 August. 0074-0077 are taken; this batch claims 0078-0083.

One handoff was written and withdrawn

CLOUD-4 was originally about #326 (moving `shape()`'s match arms into their per-operation modules). The truth-check refuted three of its claims — its measurements were eighteen days stale, and issue #326 explicitly forbids the single-sweep approach the handoff instructed, for a reason that was live inside this very batch. It is parked at `docs/handoffs/parked/CLOUD-X-issue-326-planner-shape.md`, kept rather than deleted, with the full account in `docs/handoffs/parked/README.md`. #438 took its slot.

A name collision worth knowing about

An **earlier, different** CLOUD-1 ... CLOUD-6 batch was written on 23 August and lives in `design-docs/handoffs/` — untracked, local to Tom's box, and about entirely different issues (#449 capture-refs, cold-build measurement, and so on). Some of those filenames also appear in git history from before `design-docs/` was gitignored.

So CLOUD-1 names two different jobs depending on which directory you are in. The tracked namespace here — `docs/handoffs/` — is the one that is the record; the numbers restart at 1 per batch, and the batch is identified by this section rather than by an ever-

climbing counter. If that ever stops being clear enough, the fix is a dated subdirectory per batch, not a renumber of what has already been handed to a session.

What every handoff in this batch carries

Three things the previous batch proved necessary, in every one of the six:

- **An assigned ADR number**, for the reason above.
- **A stated merge order**, because two of them touch the same files.
- **An explicit instruction to say in the PR body that `ci/browser/run.sh` is unrun** — not to leave it implicit. The browser leg cannot run in a cloud container (`landlock_abi=-1`; the server refuses to start without its strict sandbox tier and INV-13 gives it no degraded mode), and every one of the three defects found in PR #490 was found by that leg and by nothing else.

A fresh clone's server suite fails by the hundreds until `gv-sandbox` is built

This one bites **local clones on real hardware too**, not just cloud containers — codex hit it on this box on 2026-08-25, working #438 in its own clone on the SSD.

`gv-sandbox` is a sibling binary target of the server crate (`crates/git-vista-server/src/bin/gv-sandbox/`). The sandboxed tests do not link it — they **exec `target/debug/gv-sandbox` at runtime**. A target selection like

```
cargo test -p git-vista-server --bin git-vista-server
```

builds only the named binary, so in a cold clone the helper does not exist and hundreds of sandboxed tests fail at spawn. That storm looks like a catastrophic regression; it is a missing build product.

The tell: the first baseline in codex's #438 campaign reported 12/12 runs failed. It did not believe the number, dug, found the missing helper, built it explicitly, and discarded the invalid baseline. The honest baseline was 5/12.

The rule for any clone-based session: before running server tests with a `--bin` selection, build the helper once —

```
cargo build -p git-vista-server --bin gv-sandbox
```

— or run one unfiltered `cargo test -p git-vista-server` first, which builds every target of the crate. Put this line in the handoff itself; a session that has not read this file will otherwise spend its first hour on a phantom.

The 26 August batch — 2026-08-26/CLOUD-1 ... CLOUD-5

First batch to use the dated-subdirectory fix this README promised when `CLOUD-1` stopped being unambiguous — three batches now share that name, so from here a handoff's identity is `2026-08-26/CLOUD-N`, and the numbers still mean MERGE ORDER.

#	Handoff	Issue	ADR	Merge order
1	2026-08-26/CLOUD-1-issue-336-collapse-route-local.md	#336	0084	FIRST — touches the contended middleware/handlers/planner area
2	2026-08-26/CLOUD-2-issue-521-journal-rollback.md	#521	0085	before #3 — same activity/journal subsystem; its format decision lands first
3	2026-08-26/CLOUD-3-issue-487-push-fold.md	#487	0086 (reserved, may go unused)	after #2, rebased on it
4	2026-08-26/CLOUD-4-issue-520-floor-pin.md	#520	0087	independent — CI + docs only
5	2026-08-26/CLOUD-5-issue-335-signature-status.md	#335	0088	LAST — wire-format change lands on a quiet main

ADR numbers assigned up front as always: 0083 is taken; this batch claims 0084–0088, and a reserved number that goes unused stays burned rather than reassigned.

Two issues were considered and rejected by the truth-check, on the record

- **#326** (planner `shape()` arms): its own text says the arms move when a milestone touches their operation and explicitly forbids the sweep — a dedicated extraction session contradicts the tracked decision. This is the SECOND time #326 has been pulled from a batch for this reason (see the parked CLOUD-X above); it should not be offered to a session again while that policy stands.
- **#450** (lesson tool): its own sequencing says "after #92 (Explain Mode)", and #92 is open — the single sentence-source it must share with Explain Mode does not exist yet. Premature, not wrong.

Every handoff in this batch carries the three standing environment rules (baseline-diff instead of "workspace green", the `gv-sandbox` build line, the browser-leg-unrun statement) plus per-handoff citations truth-checked against 682f3061 on the morning of dispatch — two of the five issues had already drifted (functions moved by the planner split; `rewrap_error` lives in `middleware.rs` now), which is the recurring argument for checking.

Never tell a cloud session "`cargo test --workspace` must be green"

It cannot be. Every handoff in the 25 August batch said it, and every one was wrong.

A cloud container fails **320 of 915** `git-vista-server` tests on unmodified `main`, before reaching anything a handoff is about. One cause, printed 535 times in a single run:

this operation runs in the strict sandbox tier and this host cannot provide it (missing: `landlock_abi>=6`, `bwrap`). Per ADR 0029 the operation is refused rather than run in a weaker tier

268 of those tests print that refusal verbatim; the other 52 are downstream of it (`CheckFailed { GitSpawnFailed }, "couldn't run git"`). Landlock is absent from that kernel — verified by raw `landlock_create_ruleset` syscall, independently of the server's own probe — so **installing `bwrap` changes nothing**. `seccomp` and user namespaces are present; the strict tier needs all four.

Five sessions worked around this silently and none of them said so. That is the part that matters: an instruction a session cannot follow does not produce a complaint, it produces a quiet workaround and a PR whose green claim means something different from what the reader assumes.

What to write instead

Roughly 320 `git-vista-server` tests fail in your container for environmental reasons — the strict sandbox tier is unavailable there. **Run the suite on unmodified `main` first, keep that failing-test set, and compare yours against it. Only the difference is yours.** State the two counts in your PR body. Do not report a sandbox-refusal failure as a defect, and do not claim the suite is green.

The trap that makes this worse than a nuisance

Running the six `CURRENT`-writing tests at 8 threads in a container fails **20/20**. That looks exactly like a reproduction of #438's race, and it is an environment failure — the same set fails at `--test-threads=1`. A session reporting that 20/20 as a repro has reported the wrong bug convincingly.

The session that found this refused to report it, and refused to conclude from `--test-threads=1` failing that the process-global hypothesis was dead, on the grounds that the tests never got far enough to race. Both refusals were right. Its write-up is `CLOUD-4-issue-438-result.md`, and it is the most useful document the batch produced.

The general rule

Before writing an acceptance criterion, ask whether the session you are sending it to can physically satisfy it. A criterion that cannot be met is not a high bar. It is an instruction to improvise, issued to someone with no way to tell you they had to.